

He read it over and over and quoted it often to me. I keep it by my desk as part of keeping him close to me. Being insecure but undaunted, he would tell you in Kipling-like fashion to be very serious about your career and your investments, but do not take yourself too seriously. He would urge you to contemplate others' criticisms of you, but never consider them your judge. He would urge you to challenge yourself, but not judge yourself too extremely either way and, when in your eyes you've failed, force yourself to try again. And he would urge you to do the next thing, yet unfathomed.

It is that part about Mr. Buffett, his knack for evolving consistently with his values and past—doing the next thing unfathomed—that my father most admired. Moving forward unfettered by the past restraints, utterance, convention, or pride. Buffett, to my father's way of thinking, embodied some of the qualities immortalized by Kipling.

Unfortunately, there will always be a small percentage of society, but a large absolute number, of small-minded envious miscreants who can't create a life of their own. Instead they love to throw mud. The purpose of life for these misguided souls is to attempt to create pain where they can't otherwise create gain. By the time a successful career concludes, mud will have been thrown at almost everyone of any accomplishment. And if any can stick, it will. My insecure father always expected mud to be thrown at everyone, himself included, but for those he admired, he hoped it would not stick. And when mud was thrown, he would expect those he admired, in Kipling-like fashion, to contemplate the criticism or allegation without feeling judged by it. Always through Kipling's eyes!

Through a longer career than most, Warren Buffett has acquitted himself remarkably—little mud has been thrown at him and none has stuck. A testament indeed. Kipling would be pleased, as was my father. It goes back to Mr. Buffett's core values—he always knows exactly who he is and what he is about. He isn't tormented by conflicts of interest that can undermine his principles and lead to less-than-admirable behaviors. There was no mud to throw so no mud stuck. And that is the prime part of Warren Buffett you should try to emulate. Know who you are.

I am writing this introduction in part to suggest to you how to use this book. Throughout my career, people have asked me why I don't do things more like my father did or why I don't do things more like Mr. Buffett. The